Since her youth, she gave her life to the cause of socialism and fought for the sovereignty and development of the German Democratic Republic. After the fall of socialism in Europe, she received political asylum in Chile, where she maintained friendly ties with our party and especially with those of our members who were able to rebuild their lives in the GDR, receiving the welcome and fraternity of the German people … solidarity that is not forgotten.

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Characteristically, Bild greeted her demise with the headline: ‘No tears for the purple witch.’ Several newspapers did acknowledge that she, like her husband, remained utterly sincere in her beliefs.

As for Egon Krenz, he was sentenced to six-and-a-half years in prison in 1997 on four counts of manslaughter, connected with East Germans trying to cross the Berlin Wall or the border between West and East Germany. Krenz complained his trial was little more than ‘victor’s justice’. ‘I know that I am being sentenced in the name of the whole of the former East Germany. The verdict is an expression of the political will of reunited Germany. It has been delivered by exclusively West German judges.’ He began serving his sentence in 2000 and spent almost four years in prison. ‘It was an unjust trial since I acted as the head of the GDR, a sovereign state,’ said Krenz, echoing Honecker’s earlier sentiments. Now, the former ‘crown prince’ leads a quiet life in the Baltic Sea resort of Dierhagen in Mecklenburg – West Pomerania. Günter Schabowski was convicted along with Krenz but because he accepted moral guilt and denounced the GDR, he was sent to prison for only three years. He died in West Berlin in 2015. Günter Mittag was accused of using government funds to build a private home but never faced trial. He died in 1994. As for Erich Mielke, the much-feared Stasi boss, he died in May 2000, aged 92, in a nursing home in Berlin. Within hours of his funeral, flowers and wreaths left at his graveside were torn to shreds by persons unknown.